

Why do we talk so much more about the environmental impact of AI than the one of infinite scrolling of videos, streaming, etc.?

Posted by u/ProfessionalTap2400 • 0 points • 10 comments

Question is basically in the title. I definitely don't remember that we discussed emissions so much when all social media platforms started to include the concept of infinite scrolling in video format or when streaming started to boom - and to my knowledge, it still isn't brought up as much.

But aren't these similarly polluting to AI?

Comments

u/TheApiary • 2 points • 2025-09-05 15:19 UTC

You're actually totally right. Generative AI queries use a similar amount of energy to, say, watching tiktoks. A lot of people are saying it's way more, but ask them to give you numbers.

u/Natural_Promotion631 • 2 points • 2025-09-04 19:26 UTC

An AI Query still requires more energy per unit and releases higher emissions. Cumulatively sure scrolling and streaming are similar to AI but now with AI being pushed further and more companies and users adopting it the impact will obviously become higher due to how much worse it is per unit.

u/ProfessionalTap2400 • -2 points • 2025-09-04 19:28 UTC

But if companies are using them and it becomes a business tool, then what is the 'unit' you're referring to? How do we compare video content for leisure with basically a business input?

u/tulleoftheman • 1 points • 2025-09-04 21:04 UTC

If people aren't watching videos, they are still doing leisure things, because humans need to be occupied. Leisure activities are important to humans to allow us to function.

If a business isn't using genAI, then they instead use humans. Humans exist anyway and them doing work doesn't cost more energy than them doing leisure.

Its like, imagine having a choice on how to get to a location. Option 1 is that you ride with your friend who is already going there. Option 2 is that you hire a car to take you there, but the car service is low quality and you might have to double back a few times and you might just wind up in the completely wrong spot and have to call your friend to come rescue you.

Obviously Option 2 is more energy and gas spent. But then imagine that your friend wants gas money, but the car service pays for gas by pretending it will someday be able to drive to the moon and by demanding that the government pay for its gas by raising the cost of your home heating oil. That's the current scenario.

u/fissfissfish • 1 points • 2025-09-14 03:33 UTC

Hahahahahahhs, that is an amazing analogy dear. I can't even comment on its actual accuracy but I applaud it for the journey it takes you on.

u/Natural_Promotion631 • 3 points • 2025-09-04 19:31 UTC

I mean you kinda brought up the comparison yourself. Unit in this case would be an actual query for AI and streaming or scrolling hours for streaming and scrolling.

Bottom line AI is harsher on the environment.

u/ProfessionalTap2400 • 0 points • 2025-09-04 19:34 UTC

Hm yeah, I guess I'm bringing up this comparison because they're similar in the sense that both technologies are digital, publicly accessible, and would lead to a sudden jump in emissions when launched

u/tulleoftheman • 1 points • 2025-09-04 20:49 UTC

Well, keep in mind that social media took decades to build up to current usage, and thus the infrastructure built up around it. There's no equivalent infrastructure for AI and its being adopted so fast.

It's especially bad because AI is extremely not suited for what it's being used for, like business chat bots. So huge amounts of energy is being expended to create an inherently flawed product, huge amounts more to try and get it to do something it's not suited for without errors, and then eventually it has to be taken down because genAI has extremely limited business applications that make sense and AI companies lie to businesses.

u/BaconLad19 • 3 points • 2025-09-04 19:26 UTC

I believe it is because AI requires so much more electricity than social media platforms, and the generation of said power is what causes the emissions.

u/mooooonstoner • 2 points • 2025-09-04 19:25 UTC

It doesn't take the same amount of energy

u/ProfessionalTap2400 • 0 points • 2025-09-04 19:25 UTC

Per what? How are we comparing them?